Advanced Cayley: Embedding and Extending

A Comprehensive Guide to Cayley Internals

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About This Book

This is the second book in the Cayley Graph Database course series. While Book 1 focused on using Cayley to build knowledge bases and AI agent systems, this book takes you deeper into Cayley's architecture, showing you how to embed it as a library, extend its functionality, and build custom backends.

This book is for developers who want to master Cayley at a deep level, understand its internals, and leverage its extensibility to build specialized graph database solutions.

Prerequisites

Before starting this book, you should:

- Have completed Book 1 or have equivalent Cayley experience
- Be proficient in Go programming (Go 1.22+)
- Understand graph database concepts and RDF
- Be familiar with basic database concepts (indexing, transactions, etc.)

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Deployment architectures, Prometheus monitoring, backup and recovery, and high availability patterns.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this book, you will be able to:

1. **Understand Cayley's internal architecture** at a deep level
2. **Build custom QuadStore backends** for specialized use cases
3. **Create custom iterators** for domain-specific queries
4. **Embed Cayley** as a library in larger applications
5. **Extend Cayley** with plugins and custom functionality
6. **Optimize performance** for production workloads
7. **Deploy and monitor** Cayley in production environments

Code Examples

All code examples in this book are tested with:

- **Go:** 1.25.4
- **Cayley:** v0.7.7 (cloned from GitHub)

Code examples are available in the `exercises/` directory, organized by chapter.

Conventions Used in This Book

Code blocks are shown with syntax highlighting:

```
func example() {
    fmt.Println("Hello, Cayley!")
}
```

Important concepts are highlighted in bold.

File paths are shown in `monospace` font.

> ***Note:*** *Important notes and warnings are shown in blockquotes.*

Acknowledgments

This book is based on the Cayley project created by Barak Michener and the Cayley community. Special thanks to all contributors to the Cayley project for building such an extensible and well-designed graph database.

Feedback

This course is designed to be comprehensive and practical. If you find errors, have suggestions, or want to share your Cayley projects, please contribute to the community.

Let’ s dive deep into Cayley!

Chapter 1: Cayley Architecture Overview

Welcome to the advanced course on Cayley! In Book 1, you mastered the art of using Cayley to build powerful knowledge bases and AI agent systems. Now, we will go deeper. This book is for the developer who wants to understand not just how to use Cayley, but how it works, how to extend it, and how to embed it into production applications.

This chapter will provide a high-level overview of Cayley’ s internal architecture. We will dissect the system into its core components, understand how they interact, and set the stage for the deep dives in the chapters to come.

The Layered Architecture

Cayley is designed as a modular, layered system. This architecture makes it highly flexible and extensible. At a high level, the layers are:

1. **Query Language Layer**: This is the user-facing layer, where you write queries in languages like Gizmo or use the Path API.
2. **Query Planner/Optimizer**: This layer takes a query and translates it into an efficient execution plan. The plan is represented as a tree of iterators.
3. **Iterator System**: This is the heart of the query engine. Each iterator is a small, specialized component that performs a single operation (e.g., scanning, filtering, joining).
4. **QuadStore Interface**: This is the core abstraction that separates the query engine from the storage backend. All interactions with the underlying database go through this interface.
5. **Storage Backend**: This is the actual database that stores the quads, such as BoltDB, PostgreSQL, or a custom backend that you create.

This layered design means you can swap out components at any layer without affecting the others. For example, you can write a new storage backend, and the entire query engine will work on top of it without modification.

The QuadStore Interface: The Great Abstraction

The most important concept in Cayley's architecture is the `QuadStore` interface. This Go interface defines a contract that any storage backend must fulfill. As long as a database can implement this interface, it can be used as a backend for Cayley.

We will explore this interface in detail in the next chapter, but at a high level, it provides methods for:

- Adding and deleting quads.
- Querying for quads based on their subject, predicate, object, or label.
- Retrieving statistics about the graph.
- Iterating over all nodes and quads.

This abstraction is what makes Cayley so powerful. It allows you to choose the storage technology that best fits your needs, from a simple in-memory store to a distributed, fault-tolerant database.

The Iterator System: A Pipeline of Operations

Every query in Cayley is executed as a pipeline of **iterators**. An iterator is a small, focused object that performs a single, well-defined task. For example:

- `AllIterator`: Scans through all nodes or quads in the graph.
- `FixedIterator`: Represents a fixed set of nodes.
- `AndIterator`: Takes two iterators and returns their intersection.
- `HasIterator`: Filters an iterator based on a property.

When you write a query, Cayley's query planner translates it into a tree of these iterators. For example, the query `g.V("alice").Out("knows")` might be translated into a tree like this:

```
    OutIterator("knows")
        |
    FixedIterator("alice")
```

The query engine then executes this tree, with the results of one iterator flowing into the next. This pipeline model is highly efficient and allows for a great deal of optimization.

The Registry and Plugin System

Cayley is designed to be extensible from the ground up. It uses a **registry** pattern to discover and load components at runtime. When Cayley starts up, it scans for registered storage backends, query languages, and other plugins.

This is accomplished through Go's `init()` function mechanism. Any package that wants to register a component simply adds an `init()` function that calls the appropriate registration function, such as `graph.RegisterQuadStore`.

This plugin system is what allows you to add your own custom backends, iterators, and even query languages to Cayley without having to modify the core codebase.

Refs vs. Values: The Abstraction Boundary

One final concept that is crucial to understanding Cayley's internals is the distinction between **Values** and **Refs**.

- **`quad.Value`**: This is the high-level representation of a node or literal, such as `quad.String("alice")` or `quad.Int(30)`. This is what you work with in your application code.
- **`graph.Ref`**: This is an opaque, internal reference that the `QuadStore` uses to identify a value. It could be an integer ID, a pointer, or any other internal representation.

The `QuadStore` interface includes a `Namer` component that is responsible for translating between these two representations. This abstraction allows the storage backend to use whatever internal representation is most efficient, while still presenting a clean, consistent API to the rest of the system.

In the chapters to come, we will tear down these components one by one, explore their source code, and learn how to build our own. By the end of this book, you will not just be a user of Cayley; you will be a contributor and an expert.

References

[1] Cayley GitHub Repository. `graph/quadstore.go`. https://github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/blob/master/graph/quadstore.go

[2] Cayley GitHub Repository. `graph/iterator/iterator.go`. https://github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/blob/master/graph/iterator/iterator.go

Chapter 2: The QuadStore Interface Deep Dive

As we discussed in the previous chapter, the `QuadStore` interface is the single most important abstraction in Cayley. It is the contract that separates the query engine from the storage layer. By understanding this interface in detail, you will unlock the ability to create your own custom backends and to reason about the performance of existing ones.

This chapter will provide a line-by-line deep dive into the `QuadStore` interface, explaining the purpose and requirements of each method.

The `QuadStore` Interface Definition

Let's start by looking at the full definition of the `QuadStore` interface, as found in `graph/quadstore.go`:

```
type QuadStore interface {
    refs.Namer
    QuadIndexer

    ApplyDeltas(in []Delta, opts IgnoreOpts) error
    NewQuadWriter() (quad.WriteCloser, error)

    NodesAllIterator() iterator.Shape
    QuadsAllIterator() iterator.Shape

    Close() error
}
```

The interface is composed of two other interfaces, `refs.Namer` and `QuadIndexer`, and several of its own methods. Let's break these down.

`refs.Namer`: Translating Between Values and Refs

The `refs.Namer` interface is responsible for translating between the high-level `quad.Value` types that you use in your application and the internal `graph.Ref` types that the storage backend uses.

```
type Namer interface {
    ValueOf(ctx context.Context, v quad.Value) (Ref, error)
    NameOf(ctx context.Context, id Ref) (quad.Value, error)
}
```

- `ValueOf(v quad.Value) (Ref, error)`: This method takes a `quad.Value` (like a string or an IRI) and returns the backend's internal reference for it. If the value does not yet exist in the database, the backend should create a new internal reference for it.
- `NameOf(id Ref) (quad.Value, error)`: This is the reverse operation. It takes an internal `Ref` and returns the corresponding `quad.Value`.

This abstraction is critical. It allows the backend to use any internal representation it wants for its data (e.g., 64-bit integers, pointers, byte slices), while still presenting a

consistent view to the query engine.

`QuadIndexer`: The Heart of Querying

The `QuadIndexer` interface defines the methods for querying quads based on their components.

```
type QuadIndexer interface {
    Quad(Ref) (quad.Quad, error)
    QuadIterator(quad.Direction, Ref) iterator.Shape
    QuadIteratorSize(ctx context.Context, d quad.Direction, v Ref)
(refs.Size, error)
    QuadDirection(id Ref, d quad.Direction) (Ref, error)
    Stats(ctx context.Context, exact bool) (Stats, error)
}
```

- `Quad(Ref) (quad.Quad, error)`: This method takes a `Ref` that represents a quad and returns the full `quad.Quad` object.
- `QuadIterator(quad.Direction, Ref) iterator.Shape`: This is the most important query method. It takes a direction (Subject, Predicate, Object, or Label) and a `Ref` for a value, and it returns an iterator that will scan over all quads that have that value in that direction.
- `QuadIteratorSize(...) (refs.Size, error)`: This method provides an estimated size for a `QuadIterator`. This is crucial for the query optimizer to be able to reorder iterators and create an efficient query plan.
- `QuadDirection(id Ref, d quad.Direction) (Ref, error)`: This is a convenience method for quickly getting a single component of a quad without having to load the entire quad object.
- `Stats(...) (Stats, error)`: This method returns basic statistics about the graph, such as the number of nodes and quads.

Write Operations: `ApplyDeltas` and `NewQuadWriter`

All write operations in Cayley go through one of two methods:

- `ApplyDeltas(in []Delta, opts IgnoreOpts) error`: This method is used for transactional updates. It takes a slice of `Delta` objects, where each `Delta` represents a quad to be added or deleted. The backend must ensure that all of these operations are applied atomically.
- `NewQuadWriter() (quad.WriteCloser, error)`: This method is used for efficient bulk loading of data. It returns a `quad.WriteCloser` that can be used to stream large numbers of quads into the database.

Full Graph Iteration: `NodesAllIterator` and `QuadsAllIterator`

These two methods provide a way to iterate over the entire graph:

- `NodesAllIterator() iterator.Shape`: Returns an iterator that scans over every unique node in the graph.
- `QuadsAllIterator() iterator.Shape`: Returns an iterator that scans over every quad in the graph.

These are the building blocks for queries that need to consider the entire graph, such as `g.V().All()`.

Lifecycle: `Close`

Finally, the `Close()` method is responsible for cleanly shutting down the database, flushing any pending writes to disk, and releasing any resources.

By implementing these methods, you can create a fully functional Cayley backend. In the exercises for this chapter, you will get hands-on experience with this interface by creating a simple wrapper around an existing `QuadStore` that logs all of the calls to its methods. This will give you a clear picture of how the query engine interacts with the storage layer.

References

[1] Cayley GitHub Repository. `graph/quadstore.go`. https://github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/blob/master/graph/quadstore.go

[2] Cayley GitHub Repository. `graph/refs/refs.go`. https://github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/blob/master/graph/refs/refs.go

Chapter 3: Iterator System Architecture

If the `QuadStore` interface is the foundation of Cayley, then the iterator system is the engine that drives it. Every query, no matter how complex, is executed as a tree of iterators. Understanding this system is the key to understanding Cayley's performance and to creating your own custom query operations.

This chapter will explore the architecture of the iterator system, from the base interfaces to the composition patterns that make it so powerful.

The Iterator Interfaces

At the core of the iterator system are two fundamental interfaces, `Scanner` and `Index`, which are both built on top of a `Base` interface.

The `Base` Interface

```
type Base interface {
    String() string
    TagResults(map[string]refs.Ref)
    Result() refs.Ref
    NextPath(ctx context.Context) bool
    Err() error
    Close() error
}
```

- `Result()`: Returns the current value that the iterator is pointing to.
- `NextPath()`: Advances the iterator to the next valid path. A path is a complete solution to a sub-query.
- `TagResults()`: Associates tags with the current result.
- `Err()` and `Close()`: Standard error handling and resource cleanup.

The `Scanner` Interface

```
type Scanner interface {
    Base
    Next(ctx context.Context) bool
}
```

A `Scanner` is an iterator that can be advanced one step at a time using the `Next()` method. This is used for iterators that perform a sequential scan, such as `AllIterator`.

The `Index` Interface

```
type Index interface {
    Base
    Contains(ctx context.Context, v refs.Ref) bool
}
```

An `Index` is an iterator that can efficiently check for the existence of a specific value using the `Contains()` method. This is used for iterators that represent a fixed set of values or that can perform fast lookups, such as `FixedIterator` or `HasIterator`.

Iterator Composition

The real power of the iterator system comes from composition. Iterators can be combined to create more complex query operations. The two most important composition patterns are `And` and `Or`.

The `And` Iterator

The `And` iterator takes two sub-iterators and returns their intersection. It works by iterating through one of its sub-iterators and, for each value, checking if that value is contained in the other sub-iterator.

This is where the distinction between `Scanner` and `Index` becomes critical. The `And` iterator is most efficient when its right-hand side is an `Index`, as this allows for fast lookups. The query optimizer will try to arrange the iterator tree to take advantage of this.

The `Or` Iterator

The `Or` iterator takes two sub-iterators and returns their union. It simply iterates through both sub-iterators and returns all of their unique values.

The Query Optimizer

When you write a query, Cayley's query optimizer analyzes it and creates an execution plan in the form of an iterator tree. The optimizer's goal is to create the most efficient tree possible.

It does this by applying a series of transformation rules, such as:

- **Reordering `And` iterators**: As mentioned above, the optimizer will try to place the most restrictive (i.e., smallest) iterator on the left-hand side of an `And` and an `Index` on the right-hand side.
- **Pushing down filters**: The optimizer will try to apply filtering operations (like `Has`) as early as possible in the query plan to reduce the amount of data that needs to be processed by later stages.
- **Choosing the best join strategy**: For complex queries with multiple joins, the optimizer will try to choose the most efficient join order.

The optimizer relies on the `QuadIteratorSize` method of the `QuadStore` to get estimates of the size of different iterators. Accurate size estimates are crucial for the optimizer to make good decisions.

Iterator Lifecycle

It is essential to manage the lifecycle of your iterators correctly to avoid resource leaks.

1. **Creation**: Iterators are created by the `QuadStore` or by other iterators.
2. **Execution**: The query engine calls `Next()` or `Contains()` to advance the iterators and get results.
3. **Cleanup**: The `Close()` method must be called on every iterator to release any resources it holds (such as file handles or network connections).

This is typically handled automatically by the query engine, but if you are creating your own iterators, you must be careful to implement the `Close()` method correctly and to call it on your sub-iterators.

By understanding the iterator system, you can reason about the performance of your queries, identify bottlenecks, and even create your own custom query operations. In the exercises for this chapter, you will implement your own custom filter iterator, giving you a practical understanding of how these powerful components work.

References

[1] Cayley GitHub Repository. `graph/iterator/iterator.go`. https://github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/blob/master/graph/iterator/iterator.go

[2] Cayley Documentation. “Query Optimization.” https://cayley.gitbook.io/cayley/advanced-topics/query-optimization

Chapter 4: Building a Simple In-Memory Backend

Now that you have a solid theoretical understanding of the `QuadStore` and iterator interfaces, it is time to put that knowledge into practice. In this chapter, you will build your first custom Cayley backend: a simple, non-persistent, in-memory quad store.

This exercise will teach you the fundamentals of implementing the `QuadStore` interface and will serve as the foundation for the more advanced backends we will build in later chapters.

Design and Data Structures

Before we start writing code, let's think about the data structures we will need. Our in-memory store needs to be able to:

1. Store quads.
2. Assign unique IDs to values and quads.
3. Look up quads efficiently in all four directions (Subject, Predicate, Object, Label).

A simple and effective way to achieve this is with a combination of maps and slices:

- `quads []quad.Quad`: A slice to store all of our quads. The index in this slice can serve as the quad's ID.
- `values map[quad.Value]int64`: A map to store our unique values and their corresponding IDs.
- `nextValueID int64`: A counter to generate new value IDs.
- `indexes [4]map[int64][]int64`: An array of four maps, one for each direction. Each map will store a mapping from a value ID to a slice of quad IDs.

This design is straightforward and will allow us to implement the `QuadStore` interface with relative ease.

Implementing the `QuadStore` Interface

Let's walk through the implementation of the key `QuadStore` methods.

`ValueOf` and `NameOf`

These methods will manage the mapping between `quad.Value` and our internal `int64` IDs. `ValueOf` will check if a value already exists in our `values` map. If it does, it

will return the existing ID. If not, it will generate a new ID, store the mapping, and return the new ID.

`NameOf` will do the reverse, looking up an ID in a reverse mapping to find the corresponding `quad.Value`.

`QuadIterator`

This is our primary query method. It will take a direction and a value ID, look up the corresponding list of quad IDs in our `indexes`, and return an iterator that can scan over those IDs.

For this simple implementation, we can create a basic iterator that simply holds a slice of quad IDs and a current position.

`ApplyDeltas`

This method will handle adding and deleting quads. For an `Add` delta, it will:

1. Get or create IDs for the subject, predicate, object, and label of the quad.
2. Add the quad to our `quads` slice.
3. Update the four indexes with the new quad’s ID.

For a `Delete` delta, it will find the quad to be deleted and remove it from the `quads` slice and the indexes. (For simplicity, we might choose to mark quads as deleted rather than actually removing them from the slice.)

Registration

Finally, we need to register our new backend with Cayley so that it can be discovered and used. We will do this by creating an `init()` function in our package that calls `graph.RegisterQuadStore`.

```
func init() {
    graph.RegisterQuadStore("simplemem", graph.QuadStoreRegistration{
        NewFunc: func(path string, opts graph.Options) (graph.QuadStore,
error) {
            return NewSimpleMemStore(), nil
        },
        IsPersistent: false,
    })
}
```

Testing with `graphtest`

Cayley provides a comprehensive test suite in the `graphtest` package that can be used to verify the correctness of any `QuadStore` implementation. Once we have our simple in-memory store, we will write a test that runs this suite against it.

```
import "github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/graph/graphtest"

func TestSimpleMemStore(t *testing.T) {
    graphtest.TestAll(t, func(t testing.TB) (graph.QuadStore, func()) {
        qs := NewSimpleMemStore()
        return qs, func() { qs.Close() }
    }, &graphtest.Config{})
}
```

Passing this test suite will give us confidence that our backend is a correct and compliant implementation of the `QuadStore` interface.

By the end of this chapter, you will have a fully functional, albeit simple, Cayley backend. You will have gained a deep, practical understanding of the `QuadStore` interface and will be ready to tackle the challenge of building a persistent backend in the next chapter. The exercises will guide you step-by-step through the process of building and testing your in-memory store.

References

[1] Cayley GitHub Repository. `graph/graphtest/graphtest.go`. https://github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/blob/master/graph/graphtest/graphtest.go

Chapter 5: Adding Persistence with SQLite

Our simple in-memory backend is a great learning tool, but for most real-world applications, you need your data to persist. In this chapter, you will take the concepts from the previous chapter and apply them to build a persistent `QuadStore` backend using SQLite.

SQLite is a lightweight, file-based SQL database that is an excellent choice for a simple, single-node persistent backend. It will allow us to focus on the logic of the `QuadStore` implementation without the complexity of managing a separate database server.

Schema Design

Our first task is to design a SQL schema to store our quads and values. A good schema is essential for performance. We will need two main tables:

1. **`nodes`**: This table will store the mapping from our internal integer IDs to the actual `quad.Value` data.

   ```
   CREATE TABLE nodes (
       id INTEGER PRIMARY KEY,
       hash BLOB UNIQUE,
       value BLOB,
       type INTEGER
   );
   ```

   We will use a hash of the value to quickly check for existence.

2. **`quads`**: This table will store the quads themselves, using the integer IDs from the `nodes` table.

```
CREATE TABLE quads (
    subject_id INTEGER,
    predicate_id INTEGER,
    object_id INTEGER,
    label_id INTEGER,
    PRIMARY KEY (subject_id, predicate_id, object_id, label_id)
);
```

To ensure fast queries in all four directions, we will also need to create indexes on each of the `_id` columns in the `quads` table.

`Init` vs. `New`

With a persistent store, we need to distinguish between creating a new database and opening an existing one. We will implement two functions for this:

- `InitFunc`: This function will be called when a new database is being created. It will be responsible for creating the database file and running the `CREATE TABLE` statements.
- `NewFunc`: This function will be called to open an existing database. It will connect to the database file and prepare the necessary SQL statements.

We will register both of these functions with Cayley's registry.

Implementing the `QuadStore` Methods with SQL

Now, we will re-implement the `QuadStore` methods using SQL queries against our SQLite database.

- **`ValueOf`**: This will first query the `nodes` table by hash to see if a value already exists. If it does, it will return the existing ID. If not, it will insert a new row into the `nodes` table and return the new ID.

- **`QuadIterator`**: This will execute a `SELECT` query against the `quads` table, using a `WHERE` clause on the appropriate `_id` column. For example, to find all quads with a given subject, we would run `SELECT * FROM quads WHERE subject_id = ?`.
- **`ApplyDeltas`**: This method will be implemented using SQL transactions to ensure atomicity. For each `Add` delta, it will insert a row into the `quads` table. For each `Delete` delta, it will delete a row.

Performance and Optimization

Using a SQL database gives us access to a powerful query optimizer. We can leverage this by:

- **Creating the right indexes**: As mentioned above, creating indexes on all four `_id` columns in the `quads` table is crucial for performance.
- **Using prepared statements**: To avoid the overhead of parsing the same SQL queries over and over, we will use prepared statements for all of our common queries.
- **Batching writes**: When adding or deleting large numbers of quads, we will batch them together in a single transaction to reduce the overhead of transaction management.

By the end of this chapter, you will have a fully functional, persistent Cayley backend. You will have learned how to map the `QuadStore` interface to a relational database schema and how to optimize your implementation for performance. The exercises will guide you through the process of designing the schema, implementing the `QuadStore` methods with SQL, and benchmarking the performance of your new backend.

References

[1] SQLite Documentation. https://www.sqlite.org/docs.html

[2] Go `database/sql` Package Documentation. https://golang.org/pkg/database/sql/

Chapter 6: Advanced Backend Patterns

With a functional persistent backend in place, we can now turn our attention to more advanced patterns for improving performance, scalability, and robustness. This chapter will explore several advanced techniques that you can apply to your custom Cayley backends.

Caching Layers

Database queries can be expensive, especially if they involve disk I/O. A caching layer can significantly improve performance by keeping frequently accessed data in memory. There are several places where we can introduce caching in our backend:

- **Value-to-Ref Mapping**: The translation between `quad.Value` and `graph.Ref` is a very common operation. We can use an in-memory cache, such as an LRU (Least Recently Used) cache, to store this mapping and avoid repeated database lookups.
- **Quad Cache**: We can also cache the full `quad.Quad` objects for frequently accessed quads. This can be particularly effective for applications with a read-heavy workload.

When implementing a cache, it is crucial to have a clear invalidation strategy. When a quad is deleted or updated, any cached data related to it must be invalidated.

Concurrency and Locking

In a production environment, your backend will likely need to handle multiple concurrent requests. This introduces the risk of race conditions and data corruption. To ensure thread safety, you must use proper locking mechanisms.

- **Read-Write Locks**: For workloads that have many more reads than writes, a read-write lock (`sync.RWMutex`) can be very effective. It allows multiple readers to access the data concurrently, but it ensures that writes have exclusive access.
- **Fine-Grained Locking**: Instead of using a single global lock, you can use more fine-grained locking to improve concurrency. For example, you could have a

separate lock for each index or even for individual rows or values.

The choice of locking strategy depends on your specific workload and the contention points in your backend.

Specialized Indexes

While our four directional indexes are a good general-purpose solution, some applications may benefit from more specialized indexes. For example:

- **Combined Indexes**: If you frequently query for quads with a specific subject and predicate, you could create a combined index on `(subject_id, predicate_id)`. This would allow the database to find the matching quads much more quickly.
- **Full-Text Indexes**: For applications that need to search within the content of string literals, you can integrate a full-text search engine like Bleve or Elasticsearch. Your backend would be responsible for indexing the literals and then using the search engine to resolve text queries.

Memory Management

For in-memory or partially in-memory backends, careful memory management is essential to prevent your application from running out of memory. This involves:

- **Reference Counting**: As we saw in the `memstore` implementation, reference counting can be used to track how many times a value or quad is being used. When the reference count drops to zero, the object can be safely garbage collected.
- **Lazy Loading**: Instead of loading the entire graph into memory at startup, you can use a lazy loading strategy where data is only loaded from disk when it is first requested.
- **Eviction Policies**: For caches, you need a clear eviction policy (like LRU) to decide which items to remove when the cache is full.

By applying these advanced patterns, you can build a custom Cayley backend that is not only correct but also highly performant and scalable. The exercises for this chapter

will guide you through the process of adding an LRU cache to your SQLite backend and implementing a read-write lock to ensure thread safety. You will measure the performance impact of these changes and gain a practical understanding of how to optimize your backends for real-world workloads.

References

[1] Go `sync` Package Documentation. https://golang.org/pkg/sync/

[2] Wikipedia. “Cache replacement policies.” https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cache_replacement_policies

Chapter 7: Embedding Cayley as a Library

While Cayley can be run as a standalone server, one of its most powerful features is the ability to be embedded as a library directly into your Go applications. This gives you the full power of a graph database without the overhead of managing a separate service.

This chapter will walk you through the process of embedding Cayley, from initialization to querying and lifecycle management.

Why Embed Cayley?

Embedding Cayley offers several advantages:

- **Simplicity**: No need to manage a separate database server, which simplifies deployment and operations.
- **Performance**: Queries are executed in-process, avoiding network latency.
- **Flexibility**: You can programmatically configure and control every aspect of the database.
- **Integration**: Tightly integrate the graph database with your application logic.

Initializing Cayley

The first step is to create a new Cayley graph instance. You can do this by calling `cayley.NewGraph` with the name of the backend you want to use and the path to the database file (for persistent stores).

```
import "github.com/cayleygraph/cayley"

// For a persistent BoltDB store
handle, err := cayley.NewGraph("bolt", "/path/to/my.db", nil)
if err != nil {
    log.Fatal(err)
}
defer handle.Close()

// For an in-memory store
memHandle, err := cayley.NewGraph("memstore", "", nil)
```

The third argument to `NewGraph` is an `Options` map that can be used to pass backend-specific configuration.

Basic Operations

Once you have a `graph.Handle`, you can perform all of the standard Cayley operations:

- **Adding Quads**: Use the `AddQuad` or `AddQuads` methods to add data to the graph.

  ```
  err = handle.AddQuad(quad.Make("alice", "knows", "bob", nil))
  ```

- **Querying**: Create a new query by calling `cayley.StartPath` with the graph handle.

  ```
  p := cayley.StartPath(handle,
  quad.String("alice")).Out(quad.String("knows"))
  ```

- **Iterating Results**: Use an iterator to get the results of your query.

```
it, _ := p.Iterate(context.Background()).All()
for _, val := range it {
    fmt.Println(handle.NameOf(val))
}
```

Lifecycle Management

When you embed Cayley, your application is responsible for managing its lifecycle. This means:

- **Initialization**: Creating the graph handle when your application starts.
- **Shutdown**: Calling `handle.Close()` to cleanly shut down the database when your application exits. This is crucial for persistent stores to ensure that all data is flushed to disk.

A common pattern is to create the graph handle in your `main` function and use a `defer` statement to ensure that `Close()` is called.

Programmatic Configuration

Embedding Cayley gives you full programmatic control over its configuration. You can use the `Options` map to tune backend-specific settings.

```
opts := make(graph.Options)
opts["read_only"] = true

handle, err := cayley.NewGraph("bolt", "/path/to/my.db", opts)
```

This allows you to create dynamic, environment-aware configurations without having to rely on static config files.

In the exercises for this chapter, you will build a simple REST API that embeds Cayley to provide a graph-based data service. This will give you hands-on experience with all

aspects of embedding Cayley, from initialization to querying and lifecycle management.

References

[1] Cayley GitHub Repository. `cayley.go`. https://github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/blob/master/cayley.go

Chapter 8: Configuration and Customization

Effective configuration is crucial for any production-ready application, and Cayley is no exception. When embedding Cayley as a library, you gain fine-grained control over its behavior. This chapter will delve into the various ways to configure and customize your embedded Cayley instance, from backend options to query settings.

Understanding Cayley's Configuration Model

Cayley's configuration is primarily driven by the `graph.Options` map, which is passed during the `cayley.NewGraph` call. This map allows you to specify parameters that are specific to the chosen backend or to the overall graph behavior.

```
type Options map[string]interface{}
```

This generic map allows for flexible key-value pairs, where the interpretation of the values depends on the backend or component being configured.

Backend-Specific Options

Each `QuadStore` backend can define and consume its own set of options. For example:

- **BoltDB**: Might have options for `read_only`, `no_sync`, or `timeout`.
- **PostgreSQL**: Could include `host`, `port`, `user`, `password`, `database`, or `sslmode`.
- **Custom Backends**: Your own custom backends can define any options relevant to their internal workings.

It's important to consult the documentation or source code of the specific backend you are using to understand its available options.

Programmatic Configuration

When embedding Cayley, you typically configure it programmatically, rather than relying on external configuration files. This allows for dynamic configuration based on your application's environment or runtime conditions.

```
import (
        "github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/graph"
        "github.com/cayleygraph/cayley"
)

func setupCayley(dbPath string, readOnly bool) (*cayley.Graph, error) {
        opts := make(graph.Options)
        opts["read_only"] = readOnly
        opts["timeout"] = "30s" // Example for BoltDB

        h, err := cayley.NewGraph("bolt", dbPath, opts)
        if err != nil {
                return nil, fmt.Errorf("failed to create graph: %w", err)
        }
        return h, nil
}
```

This approach ensures that your Cayley instance is configured precisely as your application requires.

Customizing Query Behavior

Beyond backend configuration, you can also influence Cayley's query behavior. While the core query optimization is handled internally, you can sometimes provide hints or adjust parameters.

Custom Namespaces and Vocabularies

Cayley supports RDF-style namespaces, which can be configured to simplify your quad data. You can define custom prefixes for IRIs, making your data more readable and manageable.

```
// Example of defining a custom namespace
quad.AddNamespace("ex", "http://example.org/schema/")

// Now you can use it like:
quad.Make("ex:person1", "ex:hasName", "Alice", nil)
```

This is typically done at application startup, before any quads are added or queried.

Environment-Based Configuration

For deployment flexibility, it's common to configure applications using environment variables. You can easily integrate environment variables into your programmatic Cayley configuration.

```
import (
        "os"
        "strconv"
)

func getCayleyOptions() graph.Options {
        opts := make(graph.Options)

        if val := os.Getenv("CAYLEY_READ_ONLY"); val != "" {
                if b, err := strconv.ParseBool(val); err == nil {
                        opts["read_only"] = b
                }
        }

        if val := os.Getenv("CAYLEY_BOLT_TIMEOUT"); val != "" {
                opts["timeout"] = val
        }
        return opts
}

// Usage:
// handle, err := cayley.NewGraph("bolt", dbPath, getCayleyOptions())
```

This pattern allows you to easily adjust Cayley's behavior across different deployment environments (development, staging, production) without recompiling your application.

Overriding Default Behaviors

In some advanced scenarios, you might want to override Cayley's default behaviors. This could involve providing a custom `Namer` implementation or even replacing parts of the query optimizer. These are advanced topics that require a deep understanding of Cayley's internals, but the modular design makes them possible.

By mastering configuration and customization, you can tailor your embedded Cayley instance to perfectly fit the needs of your application, ensuring optimal performance and maintainability. The exercises in this chapter will guide you through creating a flexible configuration system for your embedded Cayley application, allowing you to experiment with different backend options and query settings.

References

[1] Cayley GitHub Repository. `graph/graph.go`. https://github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/blob/master/graph/graph.go

[2] Cayley GitHub Repository. `quad/quad.go`. https://github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/blob/master/quad/quad.go

Chapter 9: Extending with Custom Functionality

Cayley’s modular architecture not only allows for custom backends but also for extending its functionality in various other ways. This chapter explores how you can add custom features to your embedded Cayley instance, from new API endpoints to domain-specific query functions.

Adding Custom HTTP Endpoints

When running Cayley as a standalone server, it exposes a set of HTTP APIs for querying and managing the graph. When you embed Cayley, you can extend this API with your own custom endpoints. This is particularly useful for creating domain-specific APIs that are tailored to your application’s needs.

```
import (
        "net/http"
        "github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/graph"
        "github.com/julienschmidt/httprouter"
)

func createCustomAPI(handle *graph.Handle) http.Handler {
        router := httprouter.New()

        // Add a custom endpoint
        router.GET("/api/v1/my-custom-query", func(w http.ResponseWriter, r
*http.Request, _ httprouter.Params) {
                // Your custom query logic here
                // You can use the 'handle' to query the graph
                w.Write([]byte("Hello from custom API!"))
        })

        return router
}
```

You can then run this router as part of your application's web server, providing a unified API for both standard Cayley operations and your custom extensions.

Implementing Custom Gizmo Functions

Gizmo, Cayley's JavaScript-based query language, is also extensible. You can register your own custom functions that can be called from within Gizmo queries. This allows you to encapsulate complex, domain-specific logic into reusable functions.

To create a custom Gizmo function, you need to implement the `gizmo.Function` interface and register it with the Gizmo environment.

```
import (
        "github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/query/gizmo"
)

// A custom function that, for example, calculates the 'popularity' of a
node
func popularityFunc(ctx *gizmo.Context, args []interface{}) (interface{},
error) {
        // Your logic to calculate popularity
        return 100.0, nil // Return a popularity score
}

// Register the function
gizmo.RegisterFunction("popularity", popularityFunc)
```

Once registered, you can use this function in your Gizmo queries:

```
g.V().Has("type", "post").Filter(function(d) { return popularity(d) > 50 })
```

Value Type Extensions

Cayley's `quad.Value` system can be extended to support custom data types. This is useful when you need to store domain-specific data that doesn't fit into the standard types (string, int, bool, etc.).

To create a custom value type, you need to:

1. Define a Go type for your custom data.
2. Implement the `quad.Value` interface for your type.
3. Register your type with the `quad` package so that it can be serialized and deserialized.

This is an advanced feature that requires careful implementation, but it can be very powerful for applications that need to store rich, structured data in the graph.

Middleware Patterns

Another way to extend Cayley's functionality is by using middleware. You can wrap the `QuadStore` interface with your own implementation that adds extra functionality before or after calls to the underlying store. This is a great way to implement features like:

- **Logging**: Log all queries and updates to the graph.
- **Auditing**: Keep a detailed audit trail of all changes to the data.
- **Metrics**: Collect detailed metrics on query performance and data access patterns.

```
type LoggingQuadStore struct {
        graph.QuadStore
        logger *log.Logger
}

func (qs *LoggingQuadStore) ApplyDeltas(deltas []graph.Delta, opts
graph.IgnoreOpts) error {
        qs.logger.Printf("Applying %d deltas...", len(deltas))
        return qs.QuadStore.ApplyDeltas(deltas, opts)
}
```

By extending Cayley with custom functionality, you can create a graph database that is perfectly tailored to your application's needs. The exercises in this chapter will guide you through the process of adding a custom HTTP endpoint to your embedded Cayley application and creating a simple custom Gizmo function.

mo function.

References

[1] Cayley GitHub Repository. `query/gizmo/gizmo.go`. https://github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/blob/master/query/gizmo/gizmo.go

[2] Cayley GitHub Repository. `quad/quad.go`. https://github.com/cayleygraph/cayley/blob/master/quad/quad.go